

A man with dark, curly hair, a beard, and blue-rimmed glasses is smiling and holding a wooden-framed sign. He is wearing a black turtleneck sweater. The background is a dark bookshelf filled with many books.

12 Reasons
Your DevTool
Never Gets
Installed

AI DISCOVERY & MENTION

ENTRY GATE WHERE MOST TOOLS NEVER ENTER



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Developer Marketing
for B2B SaaS

- ✓ Does AI explicitly name your tool for the use-case?
- ✓ Are you cited over default incumbents?
- ✓ Do answers include real usage examples with your tool?
 - **Signal:** AI gives category answers, not your name
 - **Signal:** Competitors repeatedly cited, you're absent
- ✓ If this fails – you are not in the shortlist at all

AI ANSWER – CLICK TRANSITION

INTENT CONVERSION LAYER



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- ✓ Does the answer include a direct GitHub/docs link?
- ✓ Is your value clear in one sentence?
- ✓ Does the example reduce “thinking effort”?
 - **Signal:** Users re-search instead of clicking
 - **Signal:** High impressions, near-zero repo visits
- ✓ If this fails – Awareness never becomes evaluation

GITHUB FIRST IMPRESSION

USE CASE LANDING PAGE, NOT YOUR WEBSITE



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- ✓ Does README explain “what it replaces” instantly?
- ✓ Is quickstart visible without scroll?
- ✓ Is last commit meaningful, not cosmetic?
 - **Signal:** Stars high, commits low – hype signal
 - **Signal:** User exits without clone or scroll
- ✓ If this fails – Trust collapses in under 60 seconds

PROOF & VALIDATION

WHERE DEVS VERIFY REALITY



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- ✓ Are there production use-cases (not toy demos)?
- ✓ Do issues show real problems + maintainer responses?
- ✓ Are integrations with known tools visible?
 - **Signal:** Only curated demos, no messy real usage
 - **Signal:** Issues unanswered > 7 days
- ✓ If this fails – Tool labeled “experimental”

INSTALL & SETUP FRICTION

HIGHEST DROP-OFF POINT



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- ✓ Does install work on first attempt across environments?
- ✓ Are hidden dependencies fully exposed?
- ✓ Does setup avoid manual config loops?
 - **Signal:** "Doesn't work" issues across OS/versions
 - **Signal:** Works on maintainer machine only
- ✓ If first install fails once – 90% users never retry
- ✓ If this fails – conversion = zero

TIME-TO-FIRST-VALUE

ACTIVATION THRESHOLD



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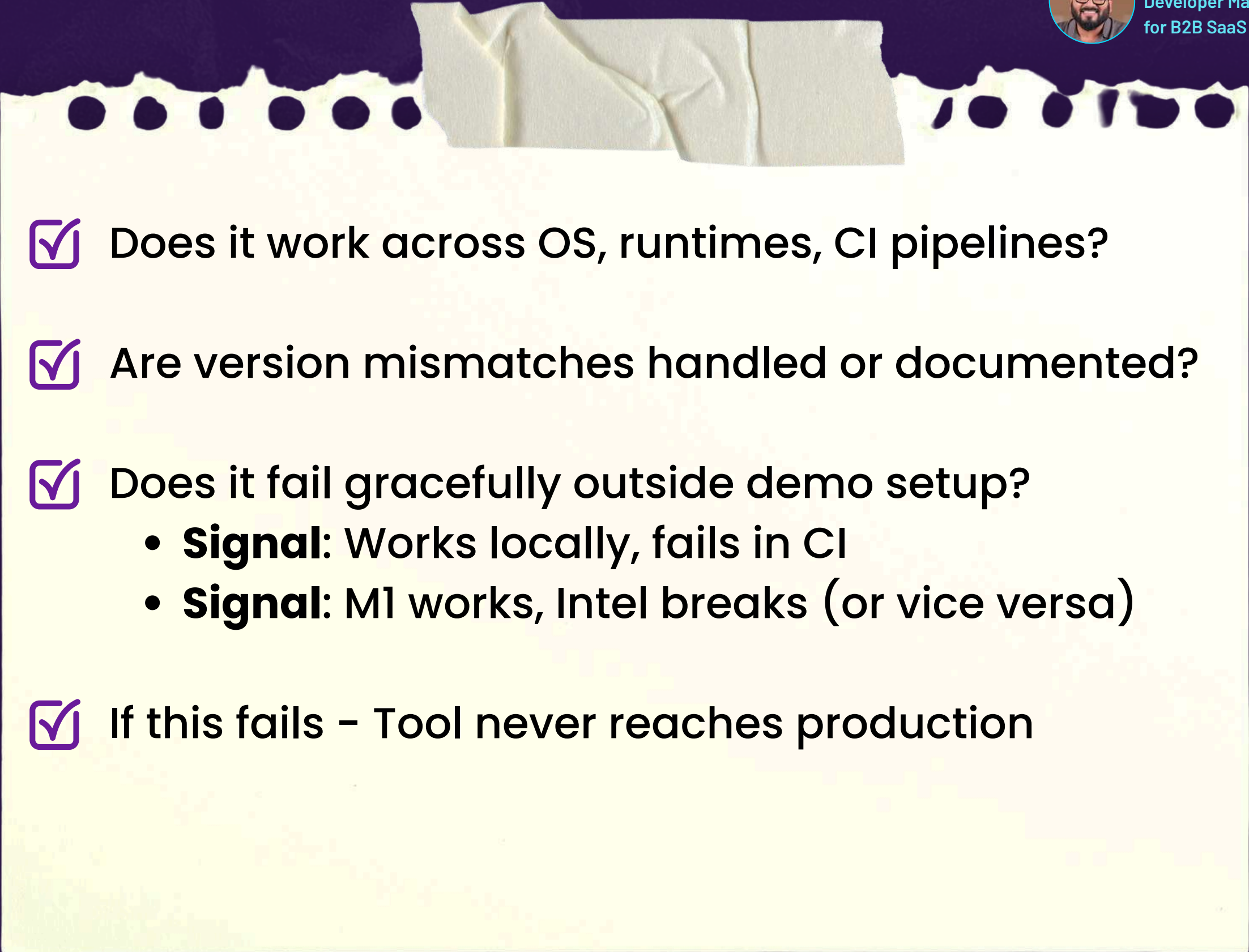
- ☑ Is there visible output in <10 minutes?
- ☑ Does default config produce meaningful results?
- ☑ Can user skip reading long docs?
 - **Signal:** Setup completes, but no output visible
 - **Signal:** Requires deep context before value
- ☑ If value is delayed – User switches tools immediately

ENVIRONMENT REALITY

WHERE MOST TOOLS SILENTLY BREAK



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- 
- ✓ Does it work across OS, runtimes, CI pipelines?
 - ✓ Are version mismatches handled or documented?
 - ✓ Does it fail gracefully outside demo setup?
 - **Signal:** Works locally, fails in CI
 - **Signal:** M1 works, Intel breaks (or vice versa)
 - ✓ If this fails – Tool never reaches production

DEBUGGING & OBSERVABILITY

POST-INSTALL SURVIVAL LAYER



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- ✓ Are logs accessible without extra setup?
- ✓ Are errors actionable, not generic?
- ✓ Is there a clear debugging path?
 - **Signal:** Errors without context or trace
 - **Signal:** No troubleshooting docs for common issues
- ✓ If user cannot debug – They abandon, not escalate

BEHAVIORAL REALITY

HOW DEVS ACTUALLY DECIDE



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- ✓ Dev opens max 2–3 alternatives – you compete instantly
- ✓ First friction – they switch, not troubleshoot
- ✓ Code proof > docs > marketing
 - **Signal:** Users compare repos side-by-side
 - **Signal:** Drop-offs after first confusion point
- ✓ If you're not instantly clear – You lose to default tools

DISQUALIFICATION TRIGGERS

INSTANT SHORTLIST KILLERS



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- ✓ No working quickstart – evaluation ends in minutes
- ✓ No real GitHub usage – “toy project” label
- ✓ No AI mention – invisible in modern discovery
 - **Signal:** Tool requires explanation to understand
 - **Signal:** No independent validation outside your site
- ✓ If any trigger hits – You are removed immediately

COMPETITIVE REPLACEMENT REALITY

WHY SWITCHING HAPPENS



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- ☑ Does this remove a painful bottleneck instantly?
- ☑ Is it 10x better, not 10% better?
- ☑ Does it reduce steps, cost, or complexity drastically?
 - **Signal:** “Nice to have” feedback, not urgency
 - **Signal:** Users test but don’t switch
- ☑ If not a clear upgrade – No adoption happens

AI RE-SURFACING LOOP

COMPOUNDING GROWTH LAYER



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- ✓ Does usage feed back into AI citations?
- ✓ Are docs structured for LLM retrieval?
- ✓ Is GitHub activity improving visibility over time?
 - **Signal:** "No increase in AI mentions despite usage"
 - **Signal:** Docs not referenced in AI outputs
- ✓ If this fails – Growth plateaus silently

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